Akhilesh has slapped Netaji"; "what kind of son is he"; "he didn't become his father's, how will he become ours". It spread. Such work should *not* be done but he spread a kind of atmosphere.'

As the audience of BJP social-media workers broke into laughter, Shah repeated his point. 'It is work that is doable [*karne jaisa*], but don't do it. Did you understand?' Again, he paused for effect, as the audience erupted in applause. 'This is work that is doable, but don't do it. We can do good work also,' he repeated for emphasis. 'The message that we want to spread—whether it is sour, sweet, true or false—that we can take to the public. But this spread could be done because we were ready with WhatsApp groups of 32 lakh people.'[72]

Conclusion: A Tale of Two Websites

In late April 2020, a month into the first COVID-19 national lockdown, I logged in to the BJP website. Its homepage had been taken over by a '#thank you corona warriors' banner. The theme dominated the party's communications. Curious to see what messaging the Congress was running, I then checked out the main Opposition party's website. Its homepage was dominated by a story on Sonia Gandhi being unanimously elected interim party president by the Congress Working Committee. This story was already a few months old at the time—an announcement made in August 2019.[73] Seven months later, in April 2020, it still remained the dominant item on the party's home page. In an environment where things change on a minute-to-minute basis, the home pages of the two rivals offered a striking visual metaphor of how the parties approached their digital political messaging. I took screenshots of both and put them away in my research files.

Figure 7.8: BJP and Congress Website Home Pages on 28 April 2020